PROJECT PRESENTATION

Maple Seed Funding Guide

Helping Canadian small and medium businesses find the funding and support that fits them.



An independent, non-commercial learning project. Katherine Borges Sato · October 2026

CONTEXT

Small and medium businesses are the backbone of Canada's economy

1.10M

employer businesses in Canada, December 2024

98.2%

of them are small businesses, with 1 to 99 employees

63.6%

of private-sector jobs, about 8 million people, in 2024

47.2%

of private-sector GDP in 2022: small 33.2% plus medium 14.0%

Source: Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada, Key Small Business Statistics 2025

THE LANDSCAPE

Support exists, but it comes from many places

- **Federal government** grants, loans, tax credits
- **Provinces and territories** vouchers, tax incentives
- **Municipalities** local programs
- **Non-profit organizations** financing, mentorship
- **Private sector** banks, accelerators

OUR PREMISE

The information is public. Finding the right program, and knowing if you qualify, is the hard part.

The federal Business Benefits Finder is published as open data under the Open Government Licence – Canada, which makes a project like this possible.

Source: Business Benefits Finder dataset, Open Government portal (Open Government Licence – Canada)

THE PROBLEM

Few small businesses use government financing, and awareness of programs is limited

1%

of small businesses requested government financing in 2024, against 24% for trade credit and 9% for debt

79%

of those government financing requests were approved, so the programs do say yes

16%

of businesses that did not use the Canada Small Business Financing Program knew it existed (34% of borrowers)

34%

of those same non-users were aware of any federal financing support program (43% of borrowers)

Sources: ISED Credit Conditions Survey 2024 (1,825 small businesses); ISED Borrower Awareness and Satisfaction Study 2023–2024

READING THE NUMBERS HONESTLY

What the data supports, and what it does not show yet

It supports

- Programs exist at scale, and 79% of government financing requests are approved.
- Awareness of specific programs is low: 16% to 34%, depending on the group.
- The audience is very large: 1.10 million employer businesses.

⚠ It does not show yet

- 79% of small businesses said they did not need financing in 2024.
- Only 1% named being unaware of financing sources as their main reason for not seeking it.
- No national figure tells us how hard programs are to find or understand.

The opportunity is for owners who do need support. This project assumes it and does not claim to have measured it.

THE OWNER'S PAIN: HYPOTHESES TO TEST

What a business owner may be thinking

1. "I do not know which programs exist for my business."
2. "I cannot tell whether I qualify."
3. "Every program site uses its own words and steps."
4. "I do not know what to prepare before applying."
5. "A wrong guess costs time I do not have."

Hypotheses from the project's design thinking, not survey results. They should be checked with feedback when possible.

THE PROPOSAL

One place to find, understand and prepare

Find

Search by Filters. A directory of programs you can narrow by provider, type of support, goal, sector and province.

Understand

Find My Support. Five short questions, then programs sorted into match, maybe and not a match, with the reason for each.

Prepare

My list and PDF. Save programs, tick off a checklist of what to prepare, and download a report to share with an accountant.

Every program links to its official website. The guide never applies on behalf of the business.

THE IDEA

Six principles behind the product

Rules, not AI

Matching follows each program's published criteria. No black box.

Always explained

Every result says why: what fits, what to confirm, what does not.

Honest

No promises and no advice. Every program links to its official site.

Private by design

Nothing is saved unless you choose. Built with PIPEDA and Québec's Law 25 in mind.

Bilingual

English (Canada) and French (Québec) from the first version.

Independent

A non-commercial learning project, not a government website.

Privacy and legal points are design guidance, not legal advice. They need review before a public launch.

STRUCTURE

How the matching works

1

Your profile

Province, sector, size, goal and structure.

2

Program rules

Published criteria for each program, entered as simple rules.

3

Check

Each criterion is marked fits, to confirm or does not fit.

4

Result

Match, maybe or not a match, with the reasons.

Data source. The Business Benefits Finder, an open dataset from the federal government.

Quality limit. Results are only as good as the rules entered and kept up to date.

In the prototype the rules cover example programs. Loading and maintaining real rules is part of the next steps.

ENGINEERING

What this project shows as software engineering

Data pipeline

Turn an open government spreadsheet into clean, structured program records.

Rule engine

Programs as data, rules as code. Small testable functions and results that explain themselves.

Product and UX

User flows, a bilingual interface, accessibility and privacy by design.

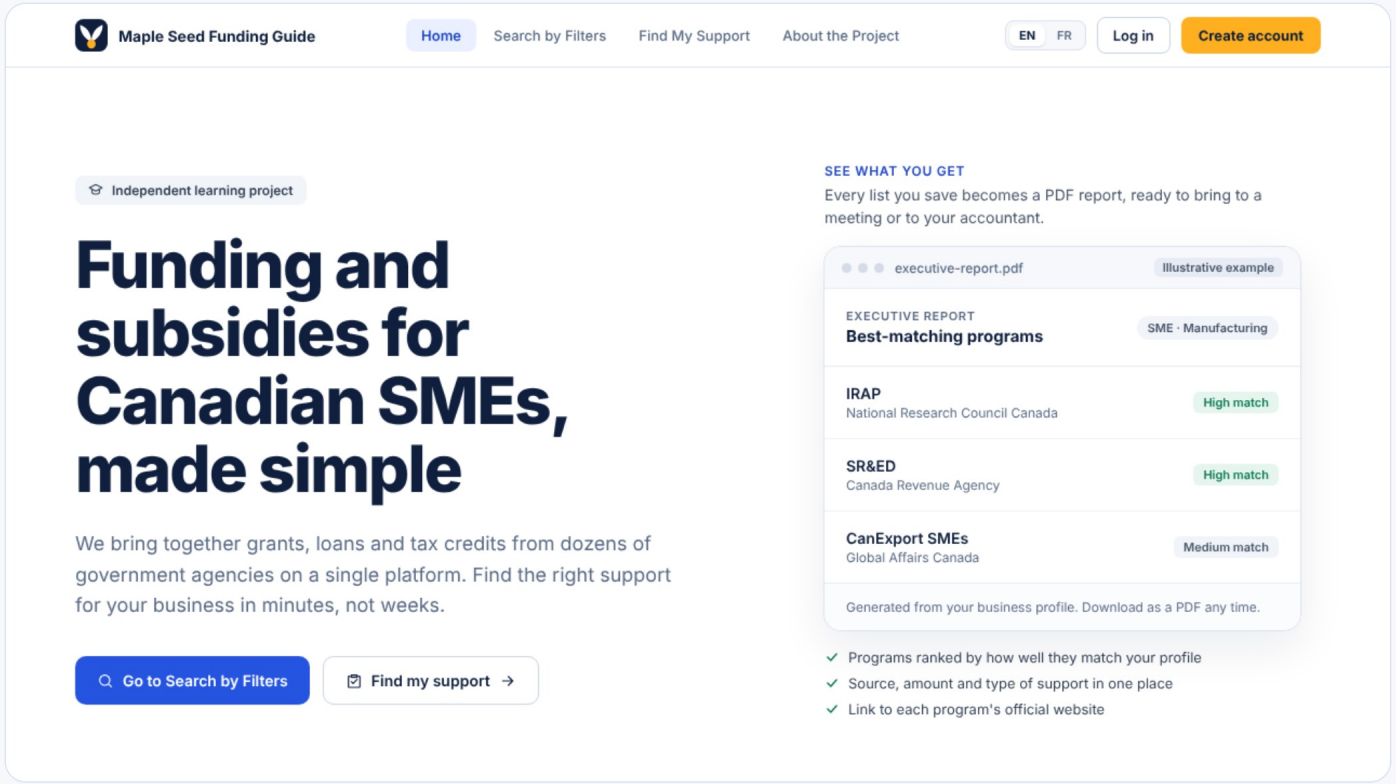
Delivery

Version control, documentation and a deployed demo.

Planned stack: [add your choice here]

DESIGN · HOME

The promise in one screen

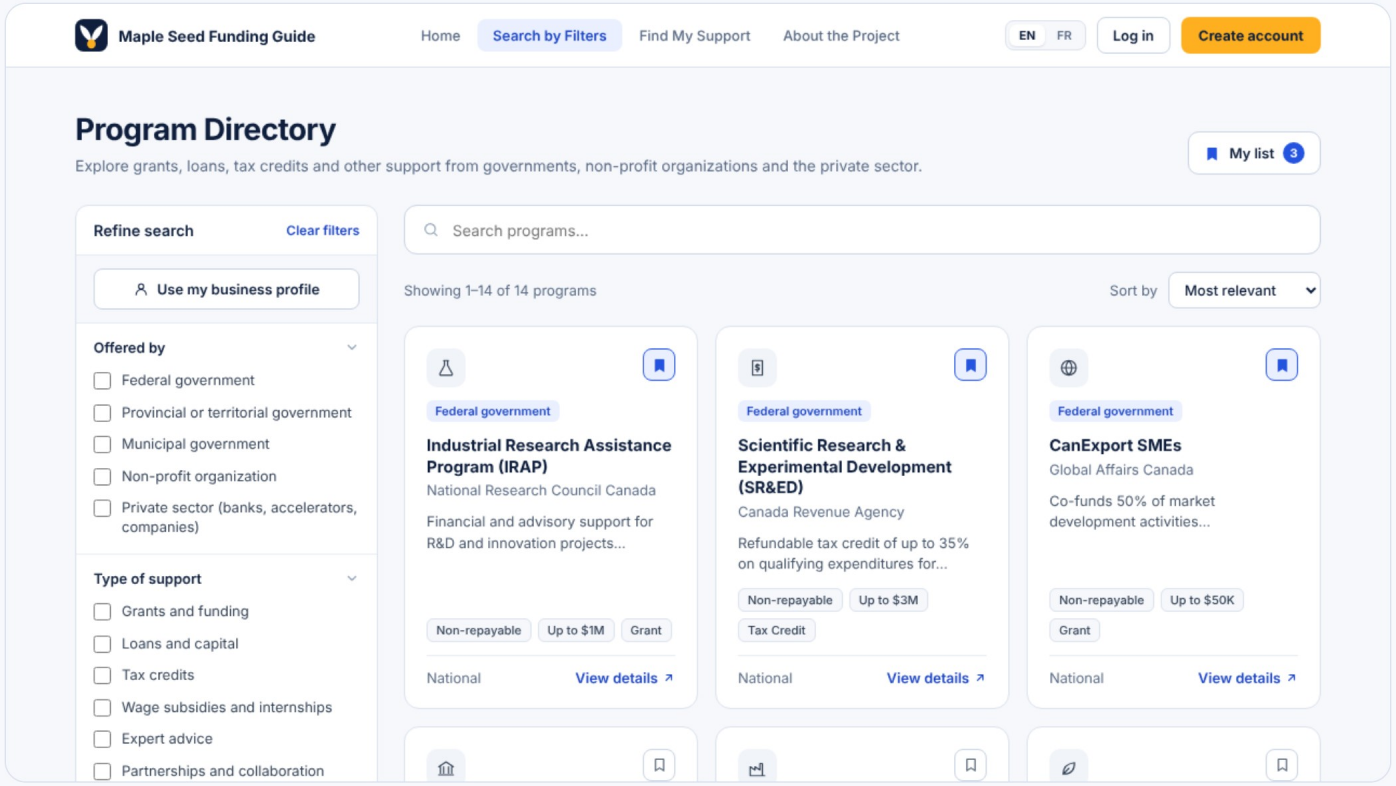


- A plain promise: funding and subsidies for Canadian SMEs, made simple.
- Two clear paths: browse with filters, or be guided.
- A sample report shows what the user gets.

Prototype screen with example data.

DESIGN · SEARCH BY FILTERS

A directory you can narrow down

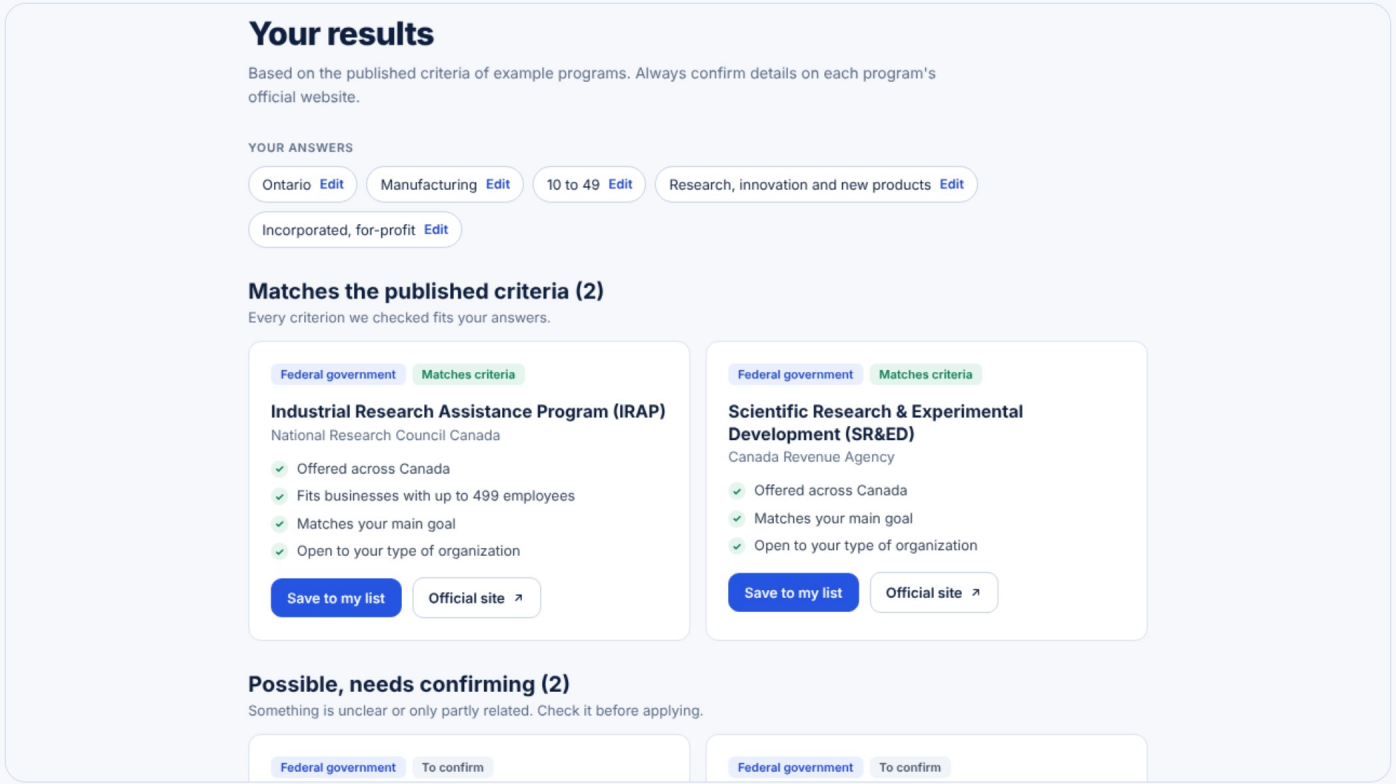


- Filters by provider, type of support, goal, sector, province, size and more.
- Each card shows the provider, type, amount and region.
- One click saves a program to My list.

Prototype screen with example data.

DESIGN · FIND MY SUPPORT

Guided matching, with the reasons shown

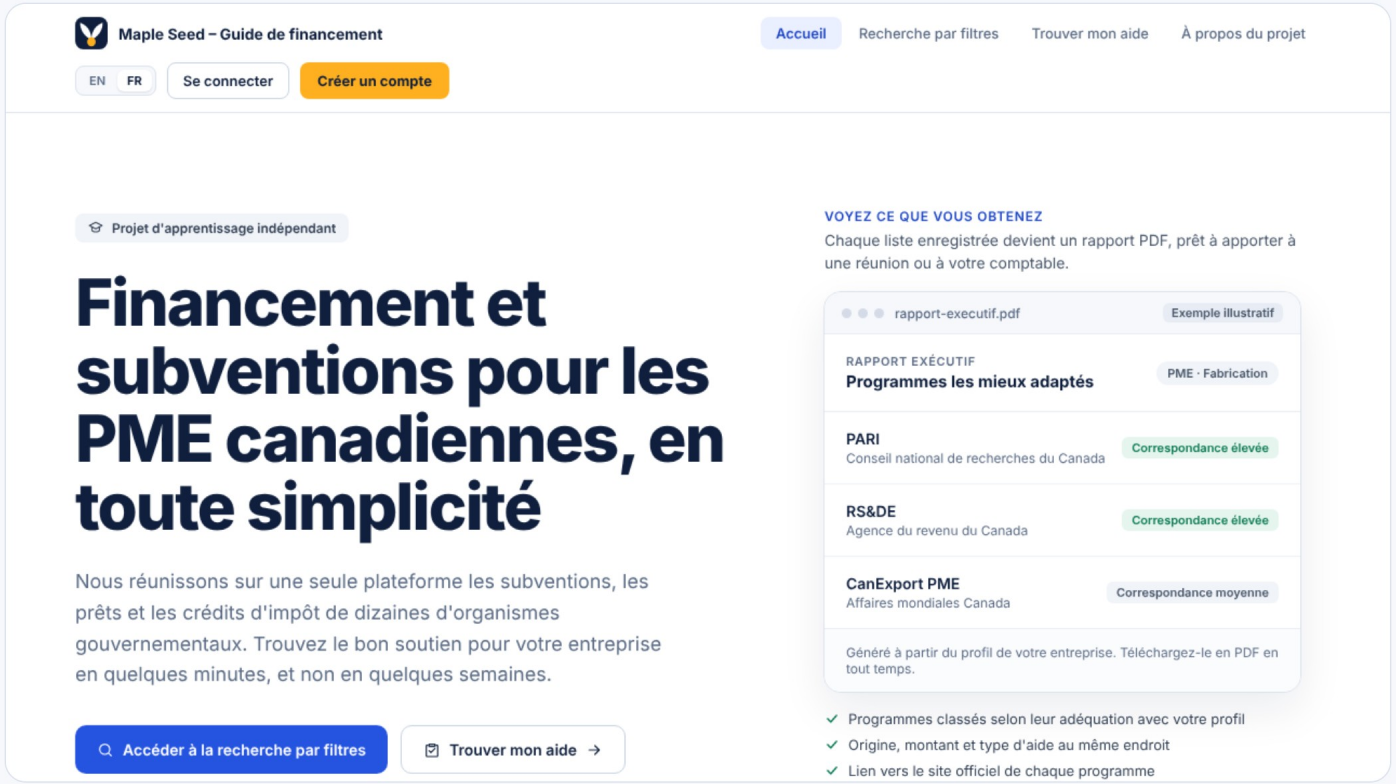


- Five questions, about two minutes, no account needed.
- Programs grouped as match, maybe, and probably not.
- Each card lists what fits and what to confirm.

Prototype screen with example programs and simplified rules. Not eligibility advice.

DESIGN · LANGUAGE AND PRIVACY

Bilingual and privacy-aware from the start



- Every screen exists in English (Canada) and French (Québec).
- On French pages the descriptive part of the name is in French.
- Consent at sign-up, a plain-language privacy notice, and a way to delete everything.

Designed with PIPEDA, Québec's Law 25 and the Charter of the French Language in mind. Needs legal review before launch.

NAME AND SYMBOL

Maple Seed Funding Guide



- **Maple** says Canadian. **Seed** says a small start that can grow.
- The symbol is a pair of maple seed wings joined at one seed: businesses and programs meeting at a match.
- It is Canadian without the flag's maple leaf, which is an official national symbol.
- "Funding guide" says what the site is, without promising money.

Availability of the name, domain and logo is not yet verified. A brand and logo record documents the full reasoning.

HOW WE CHOSE IT

Eleven rounds of ideas, one symbol



Paths, graphs, handshakes, magnifiers, lanterns, clarity, plants and a Canadian leaf came first. The maple seed pair won on clarity and meaning.

NEXT STEPS

From design prototype to a working portfolio project

Done

- Screens in English and French
- Guided matching prototype
- Brand and logo record
- Legal and privacy checklist

Next: build the MVP

- Import program data from the Business Benefits Finder file
- Write rules for a first set of programs
- Build the matching engine with unit tests
- Saved list and PDF report

Then: polish and share

- Accessibility checks (WCAG)
- Deployed demo and README
- Case study for the portfolio
- Informal feedback from a few people

Scope stays small on purpose: a working, well-documented MVP matters more than covering every program.

RISKS

Risks and how they are handled

Risk	How it is handled
Program data is wrong or old	The demo uses example data and every program links to its official page
Looks like a government service	Independent notice on every page, no flag leaf, no “Canada” in the name
Name already in use	Check domain and trademark before making the project public
Handling personal data	The demo stores no real personal data; privacy is reviewed before any real use
Scope grows too large	Keep the MVP small: a few programs, done well

The project is a portfolio demo, not a service. These notes are not a legal or financial assessment.

IN ONE SENTENCE

One place to find, understand and prepare for the support that fits your business.



Thank you. Questions and feedback are welcome.

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SOURCES

Where the numbers come from

Key Small Business Statistics 2025
ISED. Business counts to December 2024, employment 2024, GDP shares 2022. The 47.2% is the small (33.2%) plus medium (14.0%) share.

Credit Conditions Survey 2024
ISED. 1,825 small businesses surveyed January to April 2025, covering financing sought in 2024.

Borrower Awareness and Satisfaction Study 2023–2024
ISED, Canada Small Business Financing Program. Fieldwork November 2023 to January 2024.

Business Benefits Finder dataset
Open Government portal. Published under the Open Government Licence – Canada.

Figures were read from these pages in October 2026 and should be rechecked before the deck is reused.